

Second Pass — real catches from real ad scripts

Second Pass is a folder-based AI editor for Meta (Facebook / Instagram) video ads, built for laser tattoo removal clinics. You hand it an ad concept — the hook, the shot beats, the on-screen text, the copy, the offer — *before* you spend a dollar making or running it.

It does not write your ad. It names the beats that will get it skipped, waste budget, or break ad policy; cites the standard each one breaks; and hands the work back to you to fix. That distinction is the whole design — an editor, not a rewriter.

Four real findings from real ad scripts follow — the first two from my own clinic's ads, the last two from an entirely different business.

PART ONE — LASER TATTOO REMOVAL, THE ADS IT WAS BUILT FOR

CATCH 01

Twenty seconds of silence.

Source: "America's 250th" brand film — a real, shipped ad of my own

THE CATCH

Beats 1–7 carry no on-screen text and there is no voiceover, so the brand and the offer appear only at 0:20. A muted Reels viewer — which is most of them — watches a costumed man ride a hover-cycle for twenty seconds and never learns what it is for, or that there is an offer. Compounding it: the only treatment beat is AI-generated, so the ad has no real proof.

HANDED BACK — NOT REWRITTEN

"What minimal on-screen text could carry the regret-to-fresh-start line without stepping on the reveal?"

This was my own ad, and I liked it. The editor found what I couldn't see.

CATCH 02

"Your proof doesn't exist yet."

*Source: "Mother's Day" — a real, shipped ad of my own that the editor mostly **endorsed***

THE CATCH

The two proof beats are marked *"to film."* The ad's entire credibility rides on footage that does not exist yet — if those beats get skipped, faked with AI, or shot off-spec, a well-built ad collapses into a text-and-AI piece. A delivery dependency rather than a design flaw, and exactly the thing that gets lost between storyboard and launch.

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

The editor did not manufacture problems on a good ad. It named three strengths to protect, then flagged the single thing that could actually sink it. An editor that returns a long fault list for a strong ad is miscalibrated — and that is the harder half of the job.

PART TWO — THE SAME EDITOR, A DIFFERENT BUSINESS

It is not locked to tattoo removal. The industry-specific rules — the compliance red-lines, the offer framing, what counts as real proof — live in a single swappable file. Swap that one file and the same editor critiques a different field, with no changes to the core. To prove it, I pointed it at **real estate** and ran a real ad from a working agent (Melissa Bonina, Custom Homes Realty). Same critique method; an entirely different rulebook.

CATCH 03

The one person who has to be real... isn't.

Source: "old-home-surprises" — a real ad from a working real estate agent

THE CATCH

All seven beats are AI-generated — including beat 6, whose entire job is trust: *"Melissa arrives, reviewing inspection paperwork with buyers. Everyone relaxes."* In a business where the product is her judgment, the ad contains no real her, no real home she sold, and no real client. Flagged separately: a realistic AI depiction of a real, named person can trigger Meta's AI-disclosure rules — verify before it runs.

HANDED BACK — NOT REWRITTEN

"Can beats 6 and 7 be real footage of Melissa? It's the cheapest real footage in the whole ad, it's the only beat that has to be believed, and it retires the disclosure question in the same stroke."

CATCH 04

A Fair Housing landmine.

*Source: the same editor running the **real-estate** rules instead of the medical ones*

THE CATCH

"Perfect for families" flags as familial-status steering. "Safe neighborhood" flags as coded steering. "Guaranteed price" is an unverifiable claim. Any one of them can draw a HUD complaint — a category of risk that does not exist in tattoo removal, and which the editor only knows about because the rules for this industry were swapped in.

THE DETAIL WORTH NOTICING

The code caught the literal phrases; the human layer caught *"safe, family-friendly neighborhood"* — which the literal check missed because of a comma. Code catches the wording; the editor catches the meaning. And run against the realtor's *actual* ad above, the same check came back clean — a real result, not a rubber stamp.

Every run in the repo ships its exact input, the **verbatim** output of the automated pre-pass, and the full critique — all re-runnable, so none of this has to be taken on faith.

github.com/craig-atr/fb-ad-editor